appreciate these goings-on and soon created a lobby of local citizens and activated a part of the press to protest against the interference of a Vai in local customs. Such a move put paid to the prayer meetings. Kiran remembers she was advised by the state home secretary, S. L. R. Siama, to work less, and let things take care of themselves. He, of course, said it in good faith, for he cared for Kiran and did not want her to be misunderstood.

By nature, Mizos are strongly biased against the people of the plains (read outsiders), the Vais, but in Kiran Bedi they saw a person who was working *for* them and their Mizo Council. They began to appreciate and accept her. The common man was the beneficiary of her actions and he was gradually reaping the benefits. The state officials, however, looked at these happenings with some degree of scepticism, and their attitude was quite understandable. It was probably for the first time that they were seeing a police officer interacting with the public beyond the usual levels of search, arrest, prosecution and punishment. But this interaction required a lot of persuasion from, and coordination with, the supporting agencies and the community. It is this constant interaction with the community that has been the hallmark of Kiran Bedi's mode of functioning. The fact that such positive interaction has inevitably, as in the case of Mizoram, been viewed with suspicion of her intent discloses the tendency of our bureaucracy to alienate the people.

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On the domestic front, Kiran Bedi underwent an agonizing experience. Her father was enjoying the salubrious air and climate of Mizoram and indulging wholeheartedly in his favourite pastime of playing tennis during this period. One morning he complained of a sharp pain on the side of his abdomen and was taken by his wife to the hospital. Kiran also reached there and was told that some pathological tests were being done and that there was absolutely no cause for concern. A few minutes after she had returned to her office, the doctors informed Prem Lata Peshawaria (Kiran's mother) that her husband had to be immediately operated upon as the appendix could burst any moment. As the doctors and the staff of the hospital spoke only the Mizo language, she could not get to understand much but her husband, being in great pain, signed the documents for the operation. It would take only half an hour, they assured her. The operation, in fact, lasted four hours. Prem Lata Peshawaria was joined by her daughter and after a while by Swaraj Kaushal, the governor of Mizoram and a university friend of Kiran, who had great regard for Kiran's parents. Kaushal appeared stupefied that in a place where people rushed to Delhi in case of even a minor cough or infection, Kiran and her mother had agreed to a major operation! After the operation they were told that the patient was not suffering from appendicitis but that he had tuberculosis of the intestines and that the entire maze of intestines had to be brought out, cleaned, checked and placed back.

It was discovered later that while conducting such a check a portion of the intestines had been nicked. This negligence brought Parkash Lal Peshawaria almost to death's door. Acute infection and damage to major organs resulted and a severe bloating of the stomach commenced almost immediately. The principal of the Government Hospital at Silchar (in Assam), one Dr Barua, was contacted. A helicopter was requisitioned by Swaraj Kaushal to bring in the doctor. He examined the patient and administered a cut on the side of the abdomen. Copious quantities of bile and noxious fluids poured out. However, it was Swaraj Kaushal who was the one in real agony! He had sensed total danger in case Kiran's father was not sent to a properly equipped hosptial. He again requisitioned a helicopter to fly out Kiran's father to Silchar, along with the doctor, and Kiran and her mother followed by jeep.

In Silchar no other course of treatment was suggested or given except the draining of the abdominal